CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BOAT MECHANIC / MARINE TECH IN THE AI ERA

Boats break in the water, far from a road, and their owners pay happily for the person who can bring them back.

★ TL;DR — Around $75K median for marine wrench work you can enter in 6–12 months with manufacturer credentials. The catch: seasonal rush, cramped engine bays, and work that follows the weather and the water. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

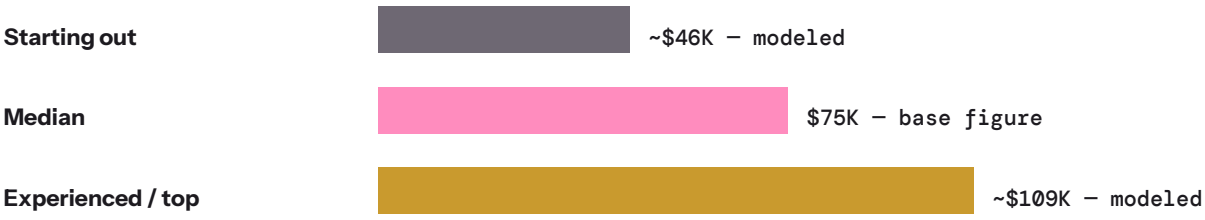
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Why it works: boats are expensive toys with salt, water and vibration eating them year-round.
- Where it bites: peak season is a sprint — everyone launches the same weekend.
- The AI angle: engine diagnostics keep getting smarter, but the failed part still sits in a bilge a human has to reach.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Boat Mechanic / Marine Tech is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BOAT MECHANIC / MARINE TECH ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Service and repair outboards, inboards and sterndrives
- ✓ Diagnose electrical, fuel and cooling problems dockside and in the shop
- ✓ Winterize, shrink-wrap, commission and launch boats seasonally
- ✓ Install electronics, pumps, steering and rigging

Think: an auto mechanic whose patients live in salt water and only get sick on holidays.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Plug-in diagnostics identify faults faster every model year. Parts lookup, service scheduling and warranty processing are heavily software-run now.	Access is the job: folded into an engine compartment, tracing corrosion that no sensor names, deciding what is safe to send offshore. That is human judgment in a tight space.

⚠ **Geography is destiny — this trade lives where boats live. Inland, the same skills transfer to small engines and RVs, but the marina premium does not.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Work at the water, not in a cubicle ✓ Owners love a good marine tech and stay loyal ✓ Seasonal rhythm: sprint, then breathe	✗ Spring commissioning season is relentless ✗ Bilges, fuel smells and skinned knuckles ✗ Winter hours can thin out in cold regions

Good fit? You like engines, water and diagnosing problems you cannot see until you open things up.
Bad fit? You want year-round steady pacing far from any coast or lake.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — MARINA / DEALER TECH TRACK	DOOR B — MARINE TECH SCHOOL
Marinas and boat dealers hire entry techs and put them through manufacturer training — Yamaha, Mercury and others certify their own systems. You earn while the brands credential you, which is the trade's main highway.	Dedicated marine programs teach engines, electrical and rigging in months, with dealer placement at the end. Faster to competence, and you arrive knowing the diagnostic workflow shops actually use.

Smart move: Get certified on electronics installs — chartplotters, autopilots, trolling motors. Rigging and electronics carry better margins and cleaner work than bottom paint ever will.

Where you land after: Master tech at a dealership, mobile marine service owner, or service manager at a marina.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ENGINE FUNDAMENTAL	GET INTO	MANUFACTURE TRAINING	RUN SERVICE	ELECTRICAL AND	OWN A

STEP 1 — Engine fundamentals

FREE · WEEKS 1-3

- Two-stroke vs four-stroke, fuel, cooling and charging systems
- Marine electrical basics — corrosion changes everything

STEP 2 — Get into a marina or dealer

PAID · MONTHS 1-2

- Apply for tech trainee and yard roles before spring rush
- Yard work — hauling, blocking, winterizing — is the side door

STEP 3 — Manufacturer training

EMPLOYER-PAID · MONTHS 2-6

- Start brand certifications on the engines your shop sells
- Learn the diagnostic software, not just the wrench work

STEP 4 — Run service tickets

SUPERVISED · MONTHS 4-8

- Oil, impellers, lower units, tune-ups — the bread and butter
- Document everything; boats come back to whoever has notes

STEP 5 — Electrical and rigging

MONTHS 6-12

- Battery systems, wiring, electronics installs
- This is the cleaner, better-paid half of the trade

STEP 6 — Own a specialty

MONTH 12

- Diesel, electronics or a dominant local brand
- Specialists get the calls generalists cannot finish

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

 Today: learn how an outboard's fuel, cooling and charging systems fit together.

- Days 1–30: apply at marinas and dealers; take yard work if that is the open door.
- Days 31–60: start manufacturer modules; shadow service tickets in the shop.
- Days 61–90: run routine services supervised and learn the diagnostic software.
- Day 90: a trainee tech inside the system — credentials stack over the first year.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ SALT WATER ALWAYS WINS. BE READY. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.